BRIGHAM YOUNG
UNIVERSITY
IDAHO

# ED 200: Education as a Profession

- **Class times: T/Th 9:00-10:00 HIN 307.**
- **Lab hours: Th/F 4-5 HIN 307. Or drop in! Penguin**

## Part I: Course Introduction

**Instructor:** Benjamin Pacini **(**But, like, call me BroPa). pacinib@byui.edu**. 801.618.7865.**** Zoom: 899.634.5818.
**Office**: Hinckley building, the one with memes on the door over by the elevator. I can't remember my office number.
**Drop-in hours:** 1 hour immediately following class, but I'm easy to find! Come drop in!*

**Course Introduction and Invitation:**
Look, I don't really like syllabi because they're filled with boring stuff like alignment tables and state standards, so here's the real meat of the class, in the form of my favorite questions:

- What is school for?
- Where did education come from?
- Who are the great figures we are learning from?
- What is great teaching?
- What will it take to become a great teacher?
- How will I know when I get there?

It's funny, when people talk about what we need to teach future teachers, they tend to focus on history and philosophy and a lot of other things that just don't make you a better teacher. If you want a class on history and philosophy of education, you'll have to go somewhere else. This class is meant to help you figure out if you want to be a teacher, and what kind of impact you can make. We also talk a lot about current events in education like policy, politics, and big debates. While this class is geared toward public education, it is useful for anyone who is considering a future that involves any teaching, whether it be in the home, church, private school, or university. Not only will I introduce you to what schools are, but also to what schools can be.

If this class isn't for you, that's ok–but make that decision early! I'm an easy-going professor, but I'll work you hard. Check out my RateMyProfessor page: the comments are honest. You'll get lots of zeroes (and it will be ok!) and we'll have delicious juicy conversations, and you'll work harder than you've ever worked, and it will be an absolute blast. Also, we like to have fun. Memes, candy, and lots of penguins. OH PENGUINS! I've hidden penguins throughout this syllabus. See how many you can find.

Teaching is the best thing in the world. It's hard. We need the very best to be teachers. But it's so, so worth it. I hope you can see what I mean once you're done in ED 200.

I could not be more thrilled to have you. Buckle up. I genuinely hope that this class changes your life.

**Brother Benjamin Pacini (BroPa)**

*Seriously, just come by. I'm off campus Mon/Wed/Fri, but other times I'm easy to find. I'll bring the memes, candy, and dad jokes. You bring… you. I guess. Or don't.
**I'm a terrible texter. I'm mediocre at answering phones, but I'm decent w/email. Best of all is the zoom channel, which I'll show in class.
***This is at penguin. PENGUIN! (Still only counts as one.)
**** Google voice is great because it has a great spam screen to keep out detestable vacuum salespeople. Say who you are, and it'll put you through.
***** See here. The RickRoll is the highest form of humor. Fight me.

**Part II: Course Breakdown and Grading:**

**Course Breakdown:**

- **Assessments**: We learn by doing, not just listening–and the assessments are our chances to do those exact things. We'll be building a website, writing essays, and putting it all together one week at a time. Some of these are quizzes, others are projects. These tell me that you've mastered core learning objectives. These will vary in length, but you should anticipate about an hour of work for each assessment.
- **Experiential Learning Activities:** Each week you will be assigned to do something that will help you learn about teaching as a profession. You should expect to be doing things, not just reading! Penguins! These will vary in length, but on average should take about an hour each week.
- **Readings:** You will be expected to complete readings each week before class begins on Thursday. We will have Harkness-style reading discussions, and students are required to come ready. Readings will be further explained in class. There are four broad topics for each week's reading:
    - **Weekly topic**. Each week, you will be required to read up on a topic we are discussing in class. This is self-directed reading, and the point is to have you study and learn on your own so you can speak to what we are talking about in class.
    - **Current events in education.** Students will be expected to read one article from an education-related periodical (including Education Gadfly, Class Disrupted, Cult of Pedagogy, Education Next, Edutopia, EdWeek, or others) of their choosing each week. These will be used to facilitate class discussion.
    - **Assigned Reading:** I will give you one short reading each week on a topic relevant to what we are learning in class.
    - **Weekly debate.** At the end of each Tuesday class, students will be given a topic for debate. They will then be expected to read up on the topic and identify what the correct answer was.
- **Book Report**
    - The class will read, over the course of the semester, Elder Bednar's "Increase in Learning." You will then complete a two page book report. (You are required to say "I read this book cover to cover" as part of submission.) Don't stress too much, it's a wonderful book, just make sure you read a little each week.
- **Contribution to Community**: One of the most important parts of this class (to me) is modeling for you how important a strong community is. This includes attendance, but also positive contribution to class, such as submitting memes to the thread, capturing great quotes, or providing a bit of daily inspiration. You will be asked to do fun, silly, joyful things just for the sake of making connections.
    - Attendance checks: Students will upload their notes, grade their own participation, and write a brief reflection of how they participated in class for each week of class. Each attendance check contains two days of attendance.
    - Teaches: We become great teachers by teaching. You will be required to teach regularly in my class for credit. Grading is based on preparedness and the extent to which students engage their peers. Students will teach at least three times, and will be graded by the professor, TA, and peers.
    - Surveys and Ratings: I am always hungry for feedback about my courses. You will be asked to give some feedback to me at midterm and end-of-semester. There is an invisible line somewhere in this syllabus that contains secret information. Highlight with your cursor to find it.

**Attendance Note:**
Attendance is necessary--but not sufficient for--success in this class. Students can miss two days of class with no penalty. After that, each day of missed class that is unexcused is a drop of a full letter grade. If a student works with me, I can excuse up to an additional four days total. Any students who misses more than six days–even in extenuating circumstances–will be required to repeat the class. Don't just participate, bring light and joy to the class.

There is a line of hidden text below. Highlight it to see what it says.

**Questions and Communication:**
In the first week of class, you will learn about our zoom channel: please check it daily. (You can check on any non-chromebook computer, or any smartphone.) While I'm always happy to answer questions, please do all you can to ask peers and consult class materials (e.g. syllabus) before reaching out. Questions that may apply to the whole class can be asked in the Zoom chat; personal questions should be emailed. I encourage people to ask their group first, the zoom channel second, the TA third, and BroPa fourth--to build your capacity to answer your own questions. That said, just ask! I love interacting with students, and will happily answer even if you go out of order.

**Grading**:
Please reference the University's grading explanation here. Letter Grades are assigned according to the following scale:

| | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| A | 93-100 | A- | 90-93 | B+ | 87-89 | B | 83-86 |
| B- | 80-82 | C+ | 77-79 | C | 73-76 | C- | 70-73 |
| D+ | 67-69 | D | 63-66 | D- | 60-62 | F | 0-59 |

**Grade Breakdown:**

| | |
|---|---|
| Contribution to Community: | 30% |
| Experiential Learning: | 35% |
| Assessments: | 35% |

Required Texts:
- Increase in Learning. David A. Bednar. Penguin. Not the publishing group lol.
- The Framework for Teaching. Danielson Group (2013)
- Teaching in the Savior's Way. The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints (Updated 2022)

## Part III: Course Expectations and Explanations:

**Required Course Materials:**

- You will need a functioning laptop. It is your job to make sure it works. (Not joking.)
- Bring a nameplate (Or make one using white card stock and black marker. Write large and clear.)
- You will need a dry erase marker, a sheet protector, and something to use to erase with (old sock is fine).
- You will need access to your BYUI email and the course zoom channel.

**Course Policies and Procedures:**

**Statement on dress code and honor code:**
I have worked in schools that have no honor code, and it makes me pretty grateful to be here. I'm a pretty big fan. I hope you are too. Do I care about little tiny rules? Not really, no. But I care a great deal about integrity–yes, even in the little things.

And while I'm only a little evil, I am evil. I am a former middle school teacher, and assistant principal. Be wise. Be kind to yourself, and keep the rules without being asked. Be kind to me by not making me have an awkward conversation. My

background is such that I will say something. Keep your promises. Keep your penguins. If you have an issue with anything, bring it up *before* you break it. I'm pretty easy to talk to about these things. Keep in mind that the honor code is a lot more than just dress and grooming–so let's do both. We'll discuss this more in class.

On Tuesdays, you're encouraged to dress up a little for devotional. I think you'd be surprised to see what a difference it can make. Also, come looking fancy on days when you are teaching. Remember "dress down" days? "Dress up" instead.

**Mastery-Based Learning and Late Work**
This class functions in the paradigm of Mastery-based learning, originally conceived of by Benjamin Bloom. It's good stuff, and you should look it up. (Here's a thing I wrote on it if you need a life or a penguin.) What this means for you is that you may keep submitting work to get the grade you desire so long as you meet the following two criteria:

1) You submit the work early (or on time)
2) You submit work that is clearly your best effort.

Late work will not be penalized, but will only be graded once. Typically it will be graded by me rather than the TAs (and I tend to be a little harsher than they are). You will not have a chance to resubmit for improved grades if you submit late. All assignments can be submitted late with no penalty, with the exception of missing too much class to pass the course.

**Zeroes**
Mastery-based learning is great because it allows you to resubmit: that means that you can keep working at it until you understand the assignment. It also allows me to set a high bar for coursework. As such, most work in my class is graded pass/fail: you either get an A or a 0. If you have a 0 in your gradebook, you should interpret it as "an assignment I haven't quite got down yet." You will get more zeroes than you are used to. Don't stress. Keep at it. Take the feedback and resubmit. Talk to me if you need.

**Peer Grading**
You will do a lot of peer grading and peer feedback. You are about to be teachers, so this is good training. I expect you to grade with **kindness, honesty, and care**. While you will give suggested grades, I am ultimately responsible for grades in this course.

Teaches cannot be made up outside of meeting with me. If you know you will miss a teach, try to swap with another teammate early. If you wake up sick, contact me to find a way to make up the teach. Please be mature and professional about extenuating circumstances. (*cough* family-vacations-aren't-emergencies *cough*) You will find me to be very understanding, if you are very responsible.

**Note on Emotional Health**
I believe strongly that creating emotionally strong, resilient students is about both decreasing stress, and increasing capacity. If discussions of emotional health are sensitive or difficult for you, please let me know as early as possible. I do not claim to have all the right ideas on this, but feel it to be important enough to bring up and discuss.

Additionally, I suspect that many of you lean toward perfectionism: teaching will help with that. You will learn, quickly, the art of "good enough." You should never feel the need to spend 3 hours on a 1 hour assignment. Be wise. Learn how to manage your own time carefully. Learn that excellence is better than perfectionism (including in grades) and know the difference between integrity and scrupulosity.

A thought on emotional health and grades: I hope all of you are aiming for an A. But I hope you realize that the real goal isn't the A, it's the learning--it's the success that you'll have in your classroom someday because of what you learned, the students' lives who will be changed, and the relationships you'll build with teachers, parents, students, and communities--and most importantly, the Lord. This is a very long-term game. You will see your success measured not in months, or even years, but decades and generations.

**Sensitive Topics, Bias, and Purpose**
I do not believe that it is in your best interest for me to avoid difficult conversations. To the contrary, learning how to wrestle with difficult topics is one of the most important things you can take from your BYU-Idaho education. An education that doesn't address the hard issues is one that isn't worth paying for. I hope that I am able to raise difficult, sensitive, challenging issues–and consistently push your thinking, even if I can't resolve them perfectly. As such, some notes:

- You're paying for me to challenge your thinking. I hope to shoot down bad ideas! At the same time, feel free to push back, so long as you are polite, civil, and articulate. Be polite and civil and articulate, but the point of the class is to learn to challenge each other in healthy ways. You will need to be ready for the push, though!
- This class touches directly on sensitive topics like psychology of gender, family structure, and plenty more. I'm not doing you a favor if I skip the sensitive stuff. If there are topics that you are sensitive about, feel free to come let me know privately. I'll do what I can to talk about these things thoughtfully, but I feel the obligation to talk through them.
- I have a point of view: I'm pretty heavily biased in the direction of what the research seems to say, for example, and I'm a believing Latter-day Saint. Sometimes viewpoint neutrality is the right course, sometimes it's important to be clear about what I believe.
- It's impossible to fully get rid of all your biases. I'll try to focus on presenting both sides of an argument when appropriate, but if I can't, I'll try to lay out my reasoning and be transparent. My intent is not to make you *think like me* but it is to *make you think.*
- Elder Paul V. Johnson has asked faculty to have both "moral courage" and "intellectual courage." That means that I'm going to stand up for things I believe in. More importantly, I'm going to encourage you to do likewise.

*On social media and my writings:*
You are welcome to follow me on social media, but you are never going to be required to. You should understand that I have opinions on things, including politics, and that we may not agree. If you are willing to be my friend, I'll be happy to add you–but I will not give any brownie points or extra credit for it.

I also have a podcast and write occasionally in various places. If you would like to listen to my podcast, please click here. (Also, and I say this with love, get a life.)

A couple of the pieces I have published may be relevant to my classes, however, so I have included them below. They are my opinion only.

**You Belong in My Classroom**: This article is an explanation of how important it is to create a safe place of belonging in my classroom, and also why I don't use pride imagery. It isn't perfect, but it may give you insight into how I feel about things. (This is the second draft of an article that first appeared at Public Square Magazine.)

**The Case for Heroic Masculinity:** this is an article on the topic of toxic masculinity, and its opposite, heroic masculinity. My basic point is simple: we need good men, not just non-toxic men. And the way we get there is through story-telling.

**Syllabus Changes**
This syllabus is a guide and every attempt is made to provide an accurate overview of the course. However, circumstances and events may make it necessary for the instructor to modify the syllabus during the semester and may depend, in part, on the progress, needs, and experiences of the students. Changes to the syllabus will be made with advance notice.

## Part IV: Standard Disclosures

**Academic Honesty**
*"When you are honest in every way, you are able to enjoy peace of mind and maintain self-respect. You build strength of character, which allows you to be of service to God and others. You are trustworthy in the eyes of God and those around you. If you are dishonest in your words or actions, you hurt yourself and often hurt others as well. If you lie, steal, cheat,*

*or neglect to give the full amount of work for your pay, you lose your self-respect. You lose the guidance of the Holy Ghost" ("Honesty," True to the Faith (2004), 84)*

Academic Honesty means students do their own work. This also means their instructors will evaluate that work. Students should not be dishonest—this includes all types of work in their courses. The complete Academic Honesty Policy can be found at http://www.byui.edu/student-honor-office/ces-honor-code/academic-honesty.

All students attending BYU-Idaho have agreed in writing to adhere to the Honor Code. Cheating, which includes plagiarism, will not be tolerated. This includes using materials you did not create and claiming them as your own. Using ideas and resources shared in the teaching community is supported, however you must give attribution and add your own ideas, experience, etc. to found resources. Please check with the instructor before using resources such as Teachers Pay Teachers and Influencer produced materials. Anyone caught cheating will receive a zero on the assignment or exam, will be reported to the Student Honor Office, and may be expelled from the course.

**Academic Support**
Go to http://www.byui.edu/AcademicSupport , or come to the McKay Library 272 for information about how the writing, reading, math, and study skills centers can help you increase your success in all of your classes. To schedule a tutor for a specific class, log on to the Academic Support website, click on Tutor Request under Student Services and follow the instructions. Penguin. I'm evil, lol. Who puts a penguin in the standard disclosures? That's like supervillain level evil.

**Academic Grievances**
Students are encouraged to contact their instructors regarding course-related concerns. If concerns cannot be resolved in this way, students may contact the BYU-Idaho Support Center to formally register a concern or grievance. The Student Grievance Policy can be found here.

**Disability Services**
BYU-Idaho does not discriminate against persons with disabilities in providing its educational and administrative services and programs and follows applicable federal and state law. This policy extends to the University's electronic and information technologies (EIT).

Students with qualifying disabilities should contact the Disability Services Office at disabilityservices@byui.edu or 208.496.9210. Additional information about Disability Services resources can be found at http://www.byui.edu/disabilities

I am very easy to work with on this. Please know, however, that the best thing I can do for any student is give them resources, empower them, and hold them to a high bar. Talk with me early if I can help in any way. PENGUIN.

**Preventing Sexual Misconduct**
BYU-Idaho prohibits sex discrimination by its employees and students in all of its education programs or activities. This includes all forms of sexual harassment, such as sexual assault, dating violence, domestic violence, stalking, conditioning a grade or job on participation in sexual conduct, and other forms of unwelcome sexual conduct.

As an instructor, one of my responsibilities is to help create a safe learning environment for my students and for the campus as a whole. University policy requires deans and department chairs, and encourages all faculty, to report every incident of sexual harassment that comes to their attention. If you encounter or experience sexual harassment, please contact the Title IX Coordinator at titleix@byui.edu or 208-496-9209. Additional information about sex discrimination, sexual harassment, and available resources can be found at www.byui.edu/titleix.